



Europe's Many Innovative Ecosystems

This article discusses the different paths taken by the member countries of the European Union towards digitalisation, which have led to massive growth and progress of people as well as technologies

Jasmin Siebert

The member countries of the European Union have taken different paths to digitalisation because of differences in their circumstances. Here are five good examples from Europe.

Czech Republic: 3D printing

The Czech Republic has a booming young IT scene. And it became active in early 2020 when the Czech government wanted to spend sixteen million euros on an online shop to sell highway permit stickers. In protest, hackers programmed the type of shopping platform required within a few days free of charge.

Today, in this former centre of heavy industry, digitalisation accounts for an above-average share of gross domestic product compared to other European countries. Informatics is a common subject at university, and out of love for their country, many Czechs would rather find their own tech startups here than emigrate. They include several world market leaders.

Cybergym Europe simulates cyberattacks in an old house in Prague. Firms from all over Europe send employees to this digital exercise ground, where they learn how to respond to hacker attacks.

The world's most commonly used 3D printer also stems from Prague. Prusa Research is considered the fastest-growing tech firm in Central Europe. Every month

the printer farm sends thousands of 3D printers all over the world. The machines print printers day and night—they basically reproduce themselves. The printers have remained an open source, which means all the programming code is freely accessible.

Estonia: Digital administration

In Estonia, it only takes a few clicks to register a change of address, apply for social benefits, update your car registration, or complete other administrative chores for which you would often have to stand in line for hours in other countries. In all, 99 per cent of all administrative tasks can be completed online.

If new parents are more relaxed in Estonia than elsewhere, it may be due to the local administration. In e-Estonia, as the Baltic country likes to call itself, a baby is immediately registered with the authorities by the hospital at birth. Applications for the birth certificate, health insurance, children's allowance, and other benefits are automatically submitted.

One reason for the advanced state of digitalisation in the Baltic country is to be found in its low population density. As the distance to local authorities is usually considerable, Estonians began working on digital solutions very early on.

Today, authorities and companies offer over 3,000 online services. To use them, you only need a citizen's ID card. This is simultaneously used as an identity card, driving licence, and health insurance card. Estonians have even been able to vote online since 2005. There are only three occasions when a trip to a government office is required—marriage, divorce, and property purchase.

Germany smart factory

The smart factory is central to Industry 4.0, the German Federal Government's high-tech

Prusa Research is considered the fastest-growing tech firm in Central Europe. Every month the printer farm sends thousands of 3D printers all over the world (Credit: www.prusa3d.com)

